jewels in her grief, and the Emperor himself retreated from romantic overtures with his other wives and never bore another child. Most importantly, he took an unprecedented step amongst the members of his dynasty and decided to construct an elaborate mausoleum for his deceased wife, the end product of which was the Taj Mahal - the "Crown of the Palaces."[2]

These events are widely agreed-upon by historians, but a lot has been added onto this set of facts over the centuries. In the European imagination, this is due in large measure to the fact that European commentators largely began encountering the Taj during the Romantic period, when they were already pre-disposed to celebrate incredible displays of emotional feeling and the concept of romantic love, itself a relatively new development in European thinking. Since that time, the tales about the Taj have gradually grown in the telling. For example, after being deposed, the Shah was imprisoned for the rest of his life in the Agra Fort only a few miles from the Taj, and tour guides tell how the Shah must have ended his days looking out his window at the outline of the tomb in the distance. While that is certainly romantic and altogether possible, there are no records documenting that. Moreover, the idea that the Shah planned to have his own tomb, a mirror of the Taj but in black marble, built facing across the river is also an idea of recent invention.